

demanding that it be carried forward lest the Americans achieve the target of a moon mission first.

Vladimir Komarov, the pilot aboard the Soyuz 1, was apparently adamant of going because the backup commander was his closest friend, Russian hero Yuri Gagarin, the first man in space. Gagarin had himself inspected the Soyuz 1 a while before the launch and sent a 10-page memo to authorities about its many fallacies and why it wouldn't work.

Sure enough, Komarov's spacecraft encountered several problems and fell back to Earth, killing the cosmonaut. The Soviet Space Programme never really recovered from this tragedy and delayed further plans to send cosmonauts to the moon, despite the successful launches of Soyuz 2 to Soyuz 10. Soyuz 11 saw another technical problem that killed three cosmonauts on board.

Eventually, once it became evident that the Americans had won the Moon Race, the Moonshot was unofficially scrapped, although work would continue on it well into the 1970s. The Soviets were well and truly behind in the Space Race now, but the introduction of the Soyuz spacecraft would remain the most significant technological advance from this period, as it would prove to be the most efficient spacecraft in history – used to this day on the International Space Station.

The Apollo-Soyuz Mission

By the mid-70s, things had changed. The US had won the race to the Moon, with six Apollo landings between 1969 and 1972. Both nations had launched space stations, the Russian Salyut and American Skylab. With the Space Shuttle still a few years off and the diplomatic chill thawing, the time was right for a joint mission.

The Apollo-Soyuz Test Project would send NASA astronauts Tom Stafford, Deke Slayton and Vance Brand in an Apollo Command and Service Module to meet Russian cosmonauts Aleksey Leonov and Valeriy Kubasov in a Soyuz capsule. A jointly designed, US-built docking module fulfilled the main technical goal of the mission, demonstrating that two dissimilar craft could dock in orbit. But the human side of the mission went far beyond that.

On July 17, 1975, the five explorers and the two craft – launched two days before – approached each other for docking. As Stafford guided the Apollo forward, Soyuz commander Leonov quipped, “Tom, please don't forget about your engine.” With a live TV audience watching, the two craft finally met: “Soyuz and Apollo are shaking hands now.”